

and then sub-leased the stores to Future. Once Future missed rental payments, it was entitled to terminate the sub-leases. The takeover of stores in February, explains Avanti T. Chande, Partner at law firm Mind Legal, was in the midst of a legal battle between Amazon and Future Group, which only complicated the relationship between the two. "From Reliance's point of view, this seems like a way to manoeuvre around the legal hassles surrounding the takeover of assets of the Future Group, even as the scheme of arrangement is pending approval in the NCLT. For Amazon, it only gears up for another stay on the said deal," she says. According to her, the lease for the stores in question are now held by Reliance and the matter of who the owners lease their property to is the prerogative of the owners, "with Amazon having no say or right to object".

As the battle rages from one court to another, within India and overseas, the real hit will be on the business. Biyani, once the man who ruled the retail landscape in India and created some of its most well-known shopping destinations, stares down at a business that he will never own again. Not only has it gone through a value erosion of unimaginable proportions, but is likely to leave behind a set of bruised investors and lenders. It is a fall from grace for a man who, at one point, was called the Sam Walton of India. By any yardstick, this remains one of the country's messiest takeover deals and the sad part is we are still not done with it. As the clock continues to tick, it is amply clear that very little of consequence will remain of Future Retail. And that is a worrying thought. **BT**